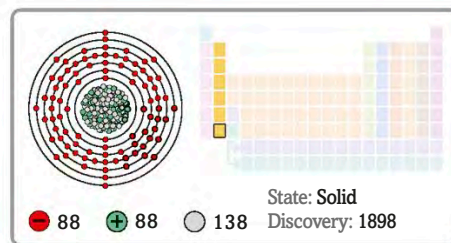


88
Ra

Radium



Forms

Chunk of uraninite

This ore contains just 0.7 g (0.02 oz) of radium in every 1,000 kg (2,205 lb) of rock.

In **100 years** time, only 4% of the radium atoms in this watch would have broken down.



Radium is the only radioactive member of the alkaline earth metals. It is also the rarest element in this group, and forms in small amounts when the atoms of more common metals – such as uranium and thorium – break down. Radium atoms do not survive for long,

with most of them quickly decaying into radon, a radioactive noble gas. This element is highly dangerous and is rarely used today. However, in the early 20th century, radium compounds were in common use. Luminous paints, like those used to make **watch dials**